



**Edinburgh Festival
Voluntary Guides
Association**

Established 1947

www.edinburghfestivalguides.org

Patron: The Lord Provost
of The City of Edinburgh

Minutes of the 76th ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING

Wednesday 12th March 2025

The City Chambers 7.00pm

1. Welcome

On behalf of the Committee, the Chair Bernard Heavie, welcomed everyone to the meeting. The following Guides were in attendance:

Olwyn Alexander, Val Baker, Fiona Beveridge, Anne Craig, Gill Davidson, Jim Eunson, Bernard Heavie, Mike Lewis, Frances McDevitt, Colin McKercher, Elspeth McLean, Sandy Macpherson, John Masson, Eric Melvin, Graham Sutherland, Fiona Watt.

2. Apologies

Gladys Bain, John Gorrie, Tom Johnston, Fiona Brownlee, Jock Anderson, Bill Thompson, Seonaid Martin, Darren Green, Veni Vounatsou.

3. Minutes of the 2024 AGM (Wednesday 14th February)

These were proposed by Elspeth McLean and seconded by Val Baker

4. The Chair's Report

Bernard expressed his thanks to CEC for allowing the EFVGA use of the European Room for the 2025 AGM. He tabled an apology from the Lord Provost who would be represented by Baillie Heap. The 2024 Festival Tours' programme had been very gratifying with nearly 1000 people taking one of our walks. This was due in no

small part to the previous decision to register with the Fringe. The vast majority of walkers had pre-booked. On occasions the maximum number of slots available (40) had been exceeded which required the committee organiser to take a walk. There were some walkers recruited on the day at the City Chambers but the numbers were very small. An analysis of the walkers showed that there was a far greater uptake for the morning walks (now starting at 10.30) compared to the afternoon. As a consequence, the rota for 2024 had been adjusted to reflect this. The agreement with St Giles which gave us short slots for both the morning and afternoon walks, had been continued. A donation of £100 had been made to St Giles in recognition of their co-operation. There had also been an increase in the number of requests for 'out of season' walks with the Association being asked to support a large international conference of TEFL delegates in April. An enjoyable reception hosted by the Lord Provost in the City Chambers had been held.

The question of the age of children participating in a tour had been discussed. Some preliminary work had been done on a worksheet to be offered to younger children. It had been agreed to raise the suitability age to 12. The Royal Scots' Club social had been well attended. Two new walks had been created - The City Walls and The Calton Hill. The possibility of offering evening tours had been discussed. The Association had joined the Edinburgh Heritage Network and the new EFVGA banner was displayed.

Finally, Bernard intimated a vacancy on the Committee and invited expressions of interest. Membership of the Committee was 'not hugely onerous.'

5. The Treasurer's Report

Jim spoke to his tabled report. The year had seen our bank balance increase from £4690 to £5220. Thought should be given to providing the Association's bank account details to those taking one of our tours. Jim was thanked for his report.

6. Committee and Office Bearers

Bernard reported the current office bearers were prepared to serve for a further year. Elspeth however had tendered her resignation having secured a place on the Blue Badge Guide training programme. Elspeth was thanked for her excellent work in managing the out of season tour requests.

7. Festival 2024 Report

Frances quoted some interesting figures for the 2024 Fringe Festival. There had been 2600 shows attended by 2.6m people from 60 different countries. The temporary toilet located to the east of St Giles had proved very popular with 11000 visits. The Association had been quick off the mark for the 2025 Festival and our Fringe entry was already on - line. The Fringe brochure would be published on 3rd June. It was agreed that we would be offering tours from 3 - 24th August. Frances was thanked for her sterling efforts.

8. Guides & Recruitment Updates.

There were currently 9 Guides in training, some of whom had been volunteer Guides at the NMS which had ended their programme of volunteer tours for visitors to the museum. Anne Craig had successfully completed her training and would be receiving her badge and scarf later in the meeting.

Sadly, Sandy Cameron, one of our most experienced Guides and a former Secretary, had passed. The Association was represented at his funeral.

A programme of visits and 4 training walks for Guides was in preparation as was the next Newsletter for which Olwyn was thanked.

9. The EFVGA Constitution

Bernard reported that a sub – committee would be looking at the current constitution and a revised constitution would be presented at the 2026 AGM.

10. AOCB

Eric reported that copies of the new EFVGA business card were available for Guides.

11.The Lord Provost (Baillie Heap)

Baillie Heap was welcomed to the meeting by Bernard. Baillie Heap spoke of the City's appreciation of the important service that has been provided by the Association since 1947. The number of visitors enjoying the walks was very impressive. He then presented Anne Craig with her badge and scarf.

Bernard expressed his sincere thanks to Baillie Heap and closed the meeting.